

World-Building Checklist for Fiction Writers

By Brandon Rohrbaugh

Introduction

This world-building checklist is designed to assist fiction writers in developing a detailed, consistent, and immersive setting for their stories. Whether your work is set in a fantastical realm, a distant future, or a small contemporary town, these guiding questions and prompts will help ensure that your world feels authentic to readers.

1. Setting & Geography

- Time Period: Historical, contemporary, futuristic, or alternate reality?
- Climate & Weather: Typical conditions, seasons, and natural disasters.
- Geography: Continents, countries, regions, landscapes, landmarks.
- Maps: Have you sketched or outlined a map for reference?
- Key Locations: Cities, villages, special sites, significant buildings.

2. Culture & Society

- Population: Species, ethnic groups, demographics, major populations.
- Language(s): Primary language(s), dialects, slang, naming conventions.
- Traditions & Holidays: Important rituals, celebrations, or festivals.
- Religion & Beliefs: Dominant religions, myths, taboos, or superstitions.
- Social Structure: Class divisions, family units, gender roles, hierarchies.
- Arts & Entertainment: Music, art, literature, sports, theater, popular culture.
- Cuisine: Staple foods, special dishes, eating habits, mealtimes.
- Fashion: Typical clothing, materials, status symbols.

3. Politics & Power

- Government: Type of rule (monarchy, democracy, council, etc.).
- Laws & Justice: Major laws, enforcement, crime, and punishment.
- Military & Defense: Armed forces, protection, historical conflicts.
- Economy: Main industries, trade, currency, wealth distribution.
- Current Events: Ongoing conflicts, political movements, social issues.

4. Technology & Magic

- Technology Level: Available tools, communication, transportation.
- Magic System (if applicable): Rules, limitations, costs, users, origins.

- **Medicine & Health:** Common diseases, medical practices, healers.
- **Daily Life:** How do technology or magic shape ordinary routines?

5. Environment & Ecology

- **Flora & Fauna:** Typical plants and animals, unique species, monsters.
- **Natural Resources:** What's abundant, what's scarce, how are resources used?
- **Environmental Hazards:** Dangerous places, predators, plagues, disasters.

6. History & Lore

- **Founding Myths:** Creation stories, legendary figures.
- **Key Historical Events:** Wars, revolutions, turning points, disasters.
- **Legacy:** How does history shape present attitudes, politics, and prejudices?
- **Artifacts & Relics:** Famous items, lost cities, sacred sites.

7. Integration Into Story

- **Point of View:** How does your protagonist perceive this world?
- **Worldbuilding on the Page:** Are details revealed naturally through action, dialogue, and character experience (not info-dumping)?
- **Consistency:** Are names, customs, and rules consistent throughout?
- **Impact:** How does the world's structure create conflict or opportunities for your characters?

Notes & Additions

Use this space to add setting-specific details or brainstorm further ideas relevant to your story's world.

Instructions:

Consult this checklist as you plan your story and return to it during revisions to ensure

depth and consistency in your worldbuilding. For further writing tools and resources, visit brandonrohrbaugh.com.